ROOTS OF HOPE

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STORIES OF HOPE, FAITH & HERITAGE

FROM THE HEART OF SYRIA'S CHRISTIAN COMMUNITIES.

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Holy Cross church - **Aleppo, 2025**

UNSHAKEN FAITH

Um al-Zunnar Cathedral - **Homs, 2024**

Um al-Zunnar Cathedral - **Homs, 2020**

on the 15th of August, Christians celebrate **THE FEAST OF THE ASSUMPTION OF THE VIRGIN MARY**, marking the belief that Marys body and soul was taken up into heaven, which is a statement of eternal life. For believers, the feast renews faith and community ties, blending solemn devotion with joyful remembrance.

SACRED SITES AND SPIRITUAL GATHERINGS

• MARMARITA: VALLEY OF THE CHRISTIANS

Known for its annual festivals, in 2025 faced cancellation of all festive activities, due to security concerns and in solidarity with the victims of the St. Elias Church attack in Damascus. The town observed the day with restraint, yet maintained deep spiritual solemnity.

Carnaval - **Marmarita, 2022**

Um al-Zunnar - **Homs, 2023**

• UM AL-ZUNNAR CATHEDRAL - HOMS

One of the oldest churches, it houses the Holy Belt of the Virgin Mary, believed to have been gifted to the Apostle Thomas and later brought to Homs, making it a major pilgrimage site.

Saydnaya - **Rural Damascus, 2022**

• OUR LADY OF SAIDNAYA MONASTERY RURAL DAMASCUS

A major eastern shrine, it hosts evening prayers and a festive morning liturgy, including an icon procession and hymns, drawing pilgrims from across the region.

• HARVEST BLESSINGS: FIRST FRUITS AND FAITH

A cherished tradition on the Feast of the Assumption of the Holy Mother of God is the Blessing of the Grapes, especially among Armenian Christians: the first grapes of the season are sanctified in church and then shared among loved ones, a gesture of thanksgiving rooted in biblical first-fruits offerings. Grapes here symbolize Christ's blood and redemption.

In the rural areas of Homs countryside and along the Syrian coast-regions that play a vital role in the feast's harvest traditions-farmers continue to endure mounting challenges. Insecurity, marked by violent incidents and targeted attacks, has disrupted daily life and jeopardized livelihoods. Beyond personal safety, the very practice of farming has become increasingly difficult: irrigation is obstructed by water shortages and damaged infrastructure; crop treatments are costly and often inaccessible; and transporting produce to markets is hampered by unsafe roads and unpredictable demand.

These ongoing hardships have placed heavy strain on an already fragile farming economy, turning the offering of **"FIRST FRUITS"** at the altar into an even more profound expression of sacrifice and resilience.

Armenian Orthodox - **Aleppo, 2025**

ROOTS OF HOPE

Latakia, 2025

“Let us hold unswervingly to the hope we profess, for he who promised is Faithful” Hebrews 10:23

Since 2013 (officially established in 2018), Christian Hope Center has been dedicated to supporting Christian families across Syria. Through a wide range of programs and initiatives, the Center seeks to serve all age groups, helping them navigate the hardships and long-term challenges brought on by war and protracted crises. A key strength of the Center lies in its meticulous follow-up and management of projects, which has fostered strong trust among donors, beneficiaries, and partners alike. From the outset, the founders anchored the Center’s mission in core Christian values, which continue to guide every aspect of its work. With this in mind, we are pleased to introduce our **“ROOTS OF HOPE”** a brief spotlight on the Center’s ongoing efforts, and a reflection of the hope that inspires our work. it also features a variety of cultural insights and updates related to Christian communities across Syria.

Latin church,
Qunayah **Idleb, 2025**

HOPE SPREAD

In support of the Christian presence, the Micro Projects Team visited the countryside of Idlib, focusing on the villages of **Al-Qunayah**, **Al-Yaqoubiyah**, and **Al-Jadida**, to assess the situation of the Christian community and register applications for small-scale projects aimed at supporting livelihoods.

Micro Project - **Mashta Azar, 2025**

2358
MICRO PROJECTS FUNDED SINCE 2018 IN SYRIA

THE SWEET TASTE OF HOPE

Beekeeping Stories | Micro Projects

In the countryside of western Syria, where hardship and uncertainty are part of daily life, hope often begins with a simple yet powerful idea. Through the Micro Projects Program, three individuals found a new path forward through one of nature’s most remarkable gifts: honey.More than just a food, honey is a symbol of health, tradition, and livelihood in Syrian culture. Beekeeping requires dedication, knowledge, and patience but with the right support, it can become a vital source of income for entire families.

HUSSAM
Mashta Azar
40 Y.O.

Hussam, a displaced teacher from Mashta Azar, turned to beekeeping to support his growing family. His outdated tools held him back, but with new equipment from the program, he expanded his production and now enjoys financial stability.

HABEEB
Bahzina
73 Y.O.

In Bahzina, Habeeb, a 73-year-old beekeeper, continued his work even after cancer cost him his voice and thieves stole many of his hives. His story of resilience and love for beekeeping moved many and with program support, his apiary is thriving once again.

ROMEO
Mashta Azar
23 Y.O.

Romeo, a 23-year-old from Mashta Azar, took over his family’s olive & beekeeping farm at a young age. Despite his hard work, he struggled to grow his work until the program provided him with modern tools. With improved production, Romeo is now able to secure a better future for his family.

Between the stones of memory and the footsteps of departure:

In an old alley of Aleppo, an elderly man sits in the shadows, holding the weight of years. Ahead, young figures walk toward the light, seeking a future far from these walls. The arches and stones remain, guarding a heritage that waits for someone to stay.

Old City - **Aleppo, 2025**

Old City - **Aleppo, 2025**

FROM ALEPPO TO HOMS: EMPOWERING FUTURE ENGINEERS IN POST-WAR RESTORATION

In line with the organization's values of empowerment and experiential learning, Study Zone Aleppo and Homs organized two specialized workshops in June and July 2025, focusing on building restoration, rehabilitation, and structural strengthening for architecture and civil engineering students.

In **Aleppo**, 25 students took part in a four-day intensive program that combined classroom-based theory with a hands-on field visit to the Old City of Aleppo, where they engaged with the full restoration process from documentation to reconstruction gaining valuable insight into preserving historic architecture in one of Syria's most culturally significant cities.

Old City
Aleppo, 2025

Wadi Al-Sayeh
Homs, 2025

Old City
Aleppo, 2025

Following that, on July 1st, Study Zone **Homs** hosted a Training session attended by 21 students. The training focused on the structural behavior of buildings - particularly columns, slabs, and floors and introduced modern techniques for damage assessment and structural documentation. The program concluded with a practical visit to Wadi Al-Sayeh, one of Homs' most affected neighborhoods, giving participants the opportunity to apply their learning in a real-world context.

Grand cathedral (Mosque now)
Old City - **Aleppo, 2025**

Old City - **Aleppo, 2025**

Old City - **Aleppo, 2025**

Old City - **Aleppo, 2025**

In a parallel initiative that reflects the center's commitment to early-stage education, a group of younger learners from the Children University program took part in a special architectural tour on May 28th, 2025, visiting Al-Manara Center - a stunning heritage palace known for its traditional Syrian architecture. During the visit, the children explored key architectural elements such as grand entrances, arches, and ornamental details in a simplified and engaging format tailored to their age group. Inspired by the experience, the young participants created basic sketches and floor plans, blending creativity, critical observation, and cultural appreciation.

Feedback from both the student workshops and the children's tour underscored the effectiveness of linking theory with practice and the importance of nurturing a generation capable of valuing and preserving Syria's architectural identity. Together, these initiatives contribute to building a more skilled, aware, and heritage-conscious future.

MARAL
Al Midan- **Aleppo, 2025**

YOU TURNED OUR HOUSE INTO A PARADISE

Stories of Healing | Aleppo

REHABILITATION

MARIAM
Al Soulaimaniya- **Aleppo, 2024**

In the neighborhoods of Aleppo, where war and disaster have left deep scars, two women Maral and Inaam - found hope and safety again within the walls of their own homes. **Maral**, 60, returned to her home in Midan after years of displacement, only to find it in ruins no doors, no windows, no roof over their heads. She and her two sons lived in harsh conditions, sleeping on bare floors with nothing but clothing to cover them. Despite the difficulties, Maral held on to her faith. She applied for help, and when the Hope Center answered, everything changed. **"YOU TURNED OUR HOUSE INTO A PARADISE"** she said, beaming with gratitude. A new balcony, secure doors, and a warm interior brought comfort back to their lives. Even after the recent earthquake, the strengthened structure offered safety. **"NOW I CAN SMILE AGAIN"** she says.

INAAM
Al Soulaimaniya- **Aleppo, 2024**

The assessment team soon visited. Together, they walked through her damaged home, and in the following weeks, repairs began. As each crack was sealed and every shattered piece replaced, **Inaam** felt her heart grow lighter. By the time the final coat of paint dried, she was standing in a renewed space not just physically restored, but emotionally healed. **"THE FEAR BEGAN TO FADE"** she said, her voice soft with gratitude. Just a few blocks away, Inaam, 66, sat in her apartment haunted by the memory of the earthquake that shook Aleppo. Her home, once filled with decades of memories, had become a constant reminder of fear and instability. Cracked walls, shattered glass, and stripped columns left her doubting whether her life would ever return to normal. But with cautious hope, she reached out to the Hope Center.

These are not just stories of home repairs they are stories of resilience, dignity, and faith rekindled. In homes once filled with dust and fear, now there is warmth, safety, and Hope. Thanks to the dedicated efforts of the Hope Center, women like Maral and Inaam are no longer vulnerable Hope Center and its partners rebuild. Because sometimes, **RESTORING A HOME IS ALSO ABOUT RESTORING A LIFE.**

43
SHOPS
RENOVATED

649
HOUSES
REHABILITATED

22
BUILDINGS
REINFORCED

An aerial photo showing the **Christian quarter** in the Jdeideh district. The photo shows historic churches belonging to the **Maronite**, **Armenian Orthodox**, **Greek Orthodox**, **Melkite Catholic**, **Armenian Catholic**, and **Syriac Catholic**.

Good Friday - **Aleppo, 2025**

Greek Melikate cathedral
Aleppo, 2025

Old City
Aleppo, 2025

Armenian orthodox church **Aleppo, 2025**

BRIDGING HISTORY & LANGUAGE: DISC STUDENTS EXPLORE ALEPPO'S ANCIENT CHURCHES

As part of their academic journey and in line with ADISC values of education and cultural openness, students from the **DISC** program in Aleppo, delivered presentations in English about the city's ancient churches, enhancing their conversation and public speaking skills. The following day,in May 2025, a field visit was organized to these historic churches, where **THE STUDENTS GUIDED THE TOUR IN ENGLISH**, sharing historical insights and connecting classroom learning with real-life practice.

The activity also aims to enhance the Christian spirit and culture of the students, so that young Christians can learn about their **CIVILIZATION AND HERITAGE** and help preserve and adhere to them.

Study Zone - **Homs, 2025**

STRENGTH IN INTEGRATION: STUDY ZONE PROMOTES INCLUSION THROUGH JOINT EVENT FOR CHILDREN

As part of its ongoing commitment to building a more compassionate and inclusive society, Study Zone organized a two-day event titled "Strength in Integration", bringing together children with special needs and students from various age groups in a shared space of learning,play, and mutual respect.

Held on July 21-22, the event was a collaborative effort between Study Zone, Helm (Dream) Center for Children with Special Needs, and the LEAP by Christian Hope Center. Designed to foster understanding and genuine connection, the event featured interactive activities aimed at encouraging empathy, cooperation, and inclusion.

A total of 35 children from **HELM CENTER** participated alongside more than 80 students, Study Zone staff, and LEAP youth leaders. The centers transformed into safe and welcoming environments where all children could thrive together.

Latakia, 2025

CARRYING THE CROSS TOGETHER

In solidarity and prayer with the families of the martyrs and the injured victims of **THE TERRORIST ATTACK AT ST. ELIAS CHURCH, AL-DWELAA, DAMASCUS**. We remain united with them in both grief and hope, bearing their suffering as our own. Offering prayers for healing, peace, and the strength to confront darkness with faith and resilience. Beyond prayer, we recognize the vital role of advocacy amplifying their voices, drawing attention to their plight, and working to safeguard their dignity and fundamental rights.we recognize the vital role of advocacy amplifying their voices, drawing attention to their plight, and working to safeguard their dignity and fundamental rights.

Latakia, 2025

LEARN TO DO RIGHT; SEEK JUSTICE, DEFEND THE OPPRESSED, TAKE UP THE CAUSE OF THE FATHERLESS; PLEAD THE CASE OF THE WIDOW.

ISAIAH 1:17

St. Elias church
Al Dwelaa, Damascus, 2025

HOPE

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